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DEMOCRACY AND NATIONALISM IN HISTORICAL PERSPECTIVE: THE CASE OF MALAWI

JOHN MCCRACKEN

ABSTRACT

The collapse of the Banda regime in 1994 has led to a renewed interest in the nature of the Malawian political tradition. This paper seeks to contribute to the debate by focusing on the political beliefs of nationalist politicians in the decade leading up to the cabinet crisis of 1964 which marks, in some views, the true origin of the Banda dictatorship. It suggests that early nationalist politicians like James Frederick Sangala and Levi Mumba combined a belief in the importance of unity with a democratic awareness of the virtues of civil society. As Congress grew in popularity, however, elements of a totalitarian ideology, deeply intolerant of dissent, began to appear, not only in Dr Banda's speeches but in those of his lieutenants and subsequent opponents such as Masauko Chipembere and Kanyama Chiume. This tendency increased with the founding in 1959 of the Malawi Congress Party which developed as an absolutist body both in terms of its own internal structure and in the demands it made on Malawian society. Some politicians drew on the autocratic tradition of the colonial era to produce justifications for the establishment of an African-controlled dictatorship. Only Dunduzu Chisiza provided a coherent democratic alternative to these views. And even Chisiza had difficulty in reconciling his belief in strongman government with the need to protect individual rights. A totalitarian strain, deeply intolerant of dissent, had thus entered Malawian politics prior to 1964. But this strain coexisted with a democratic tradition, articulated in particular by Mumba and Chisiza.

FEW EPISODES IN THE POLITICAL history of Southern Africa in the last decade have been more dramatic than the sudden collapse of the apparently impregnable Banda regime in Malawi between 1992 and 1994. Only the most naive would claim that the process of change, conventionally dated from the publication of the Roman Catholic bishops' pastoral letter in March 1992 and climaxed by the country's first genuine multi-party elections in May 1994, was brought about simply by popular revulsion against dictatorial rule. The role of the Western creditor states in reversing their previous policy and freezing aid to Malawi was a crucial

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factor in undermining the Banda regime. So too, was the gradual realignment of interests within Malawi's political elite resulting from the drying up of political patronage following the downturn of the economy from the early 1980s. Yet if external factors were crucial in forcing the government to hold a referendum on multi-party democracy in June 1993, the significance of popular responses should not be discounted. As in Eastern Europe following the collapse of the communist empire, ordinary Malawians have demonstrated considerable scepticism in recent years concerning the ability of politicians of whatever party to cope with the growing economic crisis. But they have also displayed a keen and uncomplicated concern for the protection of human rights, including the freedom of expression and association—rights previously systematically denied in independent Malawi. The ability of the Malawi Congress Party (MCP) to attract nearly 34 percent of the votes in the national elections of 1994 is an indication of how strong, in a period of flux, the attractions of authoritarian government remain. But this is not to discount the abundant evidence of popular support for an indigenous democracy based on a belief in the rule of law, on a certain separation between civil society and state, on resistance to the idea of one-party rule and, perhaps above all, on the right of the individual citizen to dissent from the government of the day in a public and regularized manner.[1]

This article seeks to make a contribution to our understanding of the struggle for democracy in Malawi by focusing on the political beliefs of nationalist politicians in the crucial decade between the mid 1950s and the cabinet crisis of August–September 1964 which marked, in some views, the true origins of the Banda dictatorship. What is at issue is less the causes and significance of the cabinet crisis itself but rather the nature of 'the Malawian political tradition'.[2] Is it the case, as the poet Jack Mapanje has suggested, that the cabinet crisis was 'the most tragic event' in Malawi's history when 'the intellectuals who had made independence possible were discredited'?[3] Or should we see it as the working out of a tradition of nationalist totalitarianism and political intolerance which had already made deep inroads into the Malawi Congress Party in the years before independence? Is Guy Mhone right to argue that the MCP by the early 1960s was already exhibiting 'incipient tendencies toward hero-worship,

1. Useful accounts of the fall of the Banda regime include Jan Kees van Donge, 'Kamuzu's legacy: the Democratization of Malawi', *African Affairs*, **94**, 375 (1995), pp. 227–57; Jonathan Newell, ' "A Moment of Truth"? The Church and Political Change in Malawi, 1992', *Journal of Modern African Studies*, **33**, 2 (1995), pp. 243–62; Trevor Cullen, *Malawi: A Turning Point* (Durham, 1994). See also Matembo S. Nzunda and Kenneth R. Ross (eds.), *Church, Law and Political Transition in Malawi 1992–94* (Mambo Press, Gweru, 1995).
2. For this term see M. L. Chanock, 'Ambiguities in the Malawian Political Tradition', *African Affairs*, **74**, 296 (1975), pp. 326–47.
3. Quoted in Leroy Vail and Landeg White, 'Of Chameleons and Clowns: Jack Mapanje', in Vail and White, *Power and the Praise Poem: Southern African voices in history* (James Currey, London, 1991), p. 286.

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centralized authoritarianism, exclusiveness and a low toleration for criticism or internal opposition'?[4] Or should we rather ask ourselves whether a democratic alternative existed to Dr Banda's authoritarian model and, if so, why it proved so ineffective at this time?

The Malawian political tradition

The establishment of the Nyasaland African Congress (NAC) in 1944 marks a convenient starting point for a study of democracy and nationalism in Malawi. The foundation of Congress is generally credited to James Frederick Sangala, a Blantyre-educated government clerk who, on 1 October 1943, addressed a circular letter to 'All Africans Resident in Nyasaland Protectorate'. In this letter Sangala stated that in previous months 'the community of both Blantyre and Limbe Townships met together to discuss the formation of an Association which should be represented by all the Africans resident in Nyasaland'.

> The chief object for forming it is because experience has taught us that unity is strength . . . It is considered that time is ripe now for the Africans in this country to fight for their freedom, progress and development of Nyasaland from one field.[5]

Questioned by colonial officials, Sangala responded by pointing to the discrimination to which Africans were exposed:

> Pass restrictions, particularly those necessary in the Townships, the lack of African representation on Legislative Council and other Official and non-Official bodies, show that the Nyasaland Natives are a subordinate race and they will remain so so long as they do nothing to improve their lot.[6]

Sangala's emphasis on the need for unity and self-improvement as a means of overcoming racial discrimination was echoed by Levi Mumba, the first President of Congress, at the inaugural meeting held on 21 October 1944. A man of similar background to Sangala, one of the pioneer graduates from the Livingstonia Institution, and for many years a senior government clerk, Mumba had a long involvement in elite political activities going back to 1912 when he became secretary of the newly-founded North Nyasa Native Association. In his presidential address, Mumba combined a demand for direct representation on the Legislative Council (though not, at this time, for majority rule) with an attack on racial

4. Guy Mhone, 'The Political Economy of Malawi: an Overview', in Mhone (ed.), *Malawi at the Crossroads* (SAPES Books, Harare, 1992), p. 4.
5. Malawi National Archives, [MNA]. NSB 3/3/6, James F. Sangala to 'All Africans Resident in Nyasaland Protectorate', 1 October 1943.
6. MNA. NSB 3/3/6, DC Blantyre to PC Southern Province, 8 October 1943. See also Richard Gray, *The Two Nations*, (OUP, London, 1960), p. 337.

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segregation and a call for 'full citizenship and consequent opportunities for all regardless of race, colour or creed'.[7]

Congress's constitution, which was Levi Mumba's final contribution to the movement prior to his sudden death in January 1945, provides an insight into his political views. Two of its central aims were:

> To work for unity of the aborigines of Nyasaland . . . in order that a well-digested native opinion may be available and ascertainable by the Government . . . [and] To encourage inculcation and practice of habits of industry, thrift and cleanliness amongst the people and to propagate the gospel of the dignity of labour.[8]

Mumba thus linked his political beliefs to the Christian values that he had absorbed at Livingstonia. Yet, as his successor, Charles Matinga, noted, 'he still remained a true African', proud of his African cultural heritage.[9] As early as the 1920s Mumba had diverged from his Livingstonia mentors by insisting in a closely argued article on the essential similarity of Christianity and 'the religion of my fathers'.[10] Later, he had combined persistent demands for the introduction of better quality education than the missionaries were providing with complaints against the social disintegration which he believed to have resulted from the European presence.

> The European came with his individualism and thrust it on the native . . . I hate individualism because it has suddenly torn the son from the father, or one man from another . . . So we see that freedom and justice which was supposed would result from the disintegration of tribal communal life has not yet been achieved.[11]

Mumba's attempt to reconcile individual advancement with communal values contains echoes both of Julius Nyerere's concept of *ujamaa* socialism and of Dr Banda's emphasis on the hierarchical, well-disciplined character of 'Our African Way of Life'.[12] Yet it is a feature of the Nyasaland African Congress in its early years that, for all its weakness as an instrument of national liberation, it remained broadly democratic in intent. Like Thompson Samkange in Southern Rhodesia, about whom Terence Ranger

7. MNA. NS 1/3/10, Levi Mumba, Presidential Address to Nyasaland African Congress, 21 October 1944.
8. MNA. NN 1/4/1, 'Nyasaland African Congress: Constitution', 1945. Levi Mumba's authorship of the constitution is confirmed in D. D. Phiri, *Malawians to Remember: James Frederick Sangala* (Longman, Lilongwe, 1974) pp. 24–5.
9. MNA. PCC 1/4/1, Charles Matinga, address to Committee Meeting of the NAC, 1 April 1945.
10. T. Cullen Young (ed.), 'The Religion of My Fathers', *International Review of Missions*, **19** (1930) pp. 362–76.
11. Quoted in Chanock, 'Ambiguities in the Malawian Political Tradition', p. 335. For further information on Levi Mumba see John McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1977), pp. 260–62, 271–2, 276, 282.
12. For a valuable discussion of Banda's views on African culture see Peter G. Forster, 'Culture, Nationalism and the Invention of Tradition in Malawi', *Journal of Modern African Studies*, **32**, 3 (1994), pp. 477–497.

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has written, Mumba and Sangala combined a belief in the importance of unity in articulating African interests with an awareness, drawn from their own experiences, of the value of the variety of associations and interests groups representative of civil society.[13] Sangala, for example, combined his role as chief organizer of Congress in the 1940s with active participation in the Parents and Guardians Educational Association, the Black and White Club, the Shire Highland Football League and the Blantyre African Co-operative Trading Society.[14] Congress, in consequence, developed as an umbrella organization linked to associations of farmers, workers and traders as well as to branch members spread throughout Nyasaland and beyond—in Northern and Southern Rhodesia and South Africa.

The growth of Congress to a high point of some 5,000 paid-up members in 1953 had the effect of shifting its political aims. In theory, membership was open from the first to 'all men and women ... belonging to the aboriginal races of Africa who are 18 years and over'.[15] In practice, however, only 'educated' men were encouraged to attend along with a handful of women, most of whom were the wives of male delegates.[16] Universal suffrage was not a demand; instead Congress advocated 'the appointment of intelligent progressive Africans in all Government Advisory Committees'.[17]

The dispute over colonial plans to bring Nyasaland into a federation with the Rhodesias, however, raised the political temperature and encouraged a new approach. In the early stages, leaders of Congress reverted to the argument that as Nyasaland was a protectorate, it was the responsibility of the King as 'our Guardian' to protect Nyasas 'from enemies within and enemies without; ... enemies whose ambitions and aims are to rob us of our land by their cunning and political traps'.[18] By 1951, however, Congress had rejected 'the philosophy that Black men should be ruled by a White aristocracy, however benevolent' and instead was demanding 'our legitimate rights, including the right to self-determination, the right to reach political manhood, the right to Govern ourselves'. This involved the classic request that 'the democratic system of franchise be introduced in the form of adult suffrage'. But it also included the more unusual demand

13. Terence Ranger, *Are We Not Men? The Samkange family & African politics in Zimbabwe 1920–64* (James Currey, London, 1995), p. 159. As Ranger notes, Samkange corresponded with Sangala on the possible federation of the NAC and the Southern Rhodesian Bantu Congress.
14. Phiri, *James Frederick Sangala*, pp. 11–16. For further information on Sangala's involvement in the Parents and Guardians Educational Association and in the Blantyre African Co-operative Trading Society see MNA. NSB 3/3/6.
15. MNA. NN 1/4/6, 'Nyasaland African Congress: Constitution', 1945.
16. MNA. NN 1/4/1, Record of the Proceedings of the Fourth Conference of the Nyasaland African Congress, September 1947. Only two out of 56 members attending this meeting were women, one of them being Mrs C. Matinga, the wife of the President-General.
17. MNA. NN 1/4/6, Constitution, 1945.
18. MNA. NN 1/4/6, Minutes of the Lusaka Branch of the Nyasaland African Congress, 12 March 1949.

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that no chief should be deposed by the government 'without the consent of the majority of his people in the area'.[19] Popular sovereignty was thus conceived as operating as much at the level of the rural locality as it did at the level of the state. Somewhat belatedly, Ralph Chinyama, the new president-general, took the decision to open up membership of Congress to a wider constituency by reducing the substantial annual fee of 5 shillings to the more realistic sum of 3 pence. Additional branches were established in the countryside with the result that, by November 1952 Congress was said to have 'representatives in all the main villages, particularly around the Native Authority headquarters'.[20]

As the debate intensified, freedom of speech and freedom to dissent became increasingly controversial issues. As we have seen, unity had always been a fundamental aim of Congress politicians, justifying their claim to speak for the African people of Nyasaland as a whole. The appearance, therefore, from 1951 of a group of chiefs and politicians who publicly flouted Congress's policy of boycotting all discussion of federation came as a major blow eliciting a fierce response. Such men were 'Quislings', wrote A. J. Banda, the General Secretary of Congress, men who were acting against 'the expressed feelings of the people'.[21] In an ironic touch, it was Dr Hastings Banda from his surgery in London who upheld the belief that more could be achieved by courting waverers than by outright condemnation. In a note to the journalist, Elias Mtepuka, Banda wrote:

> In politics it is often necessary to use tactics and diplomacy . . . To the authorities we must be as firm as possible and within the law first, but even outside the law when all constitutional and legal means fail to defeat federation. But to our own people, that is those who do not see things the way we see things, we must be very tactful, diplomatic and even lenient to their mistakes and errors which come from their ignorance.[22]

In the next few months, Banda went out of his way to convince Congress leaders of the need to involve chiefs in the anti-federation campaign so that they could speak with a single voice. 'If we do that no British Government, whatever its political colour, will dare to force us into accepting Federation. There is a thing called British public opinion which all Governments really fear.'[23]

Dr Banda's spectacular miscalculation of the British Government's political intentions can be seen in retrospect as one of the principle turning

19. Public Record Office, Kew [PRO]. CO 1015/404, Nyasaland African Congress manifesto presented to Colonial Secretary, James Griffiths, 28 August 1951.
20. PRO. CO 1015/464, Political Intelligence Reports for May and November 1952.
21. PRO. CO 1015/404, 'The Truth about the African Protectorate Council' by A. J. Mtalika Banda, 9 September 1951.
22. Quoted in PRO. CO 1015/464, Political Intelligence Report, September 1951.
23. PRO. CO 1015/464, Political Intelligence Report, November 1951.

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points in the history of democracy in Malawi. As a supporter of the British Labour Party for which he had canvassed in the landslide election of 1945, Banda was one of the very few Malawians in the early 1950s with direct experience of parliamentary democracy in practice.[24] The crushing demonstration provided by the Government in 1953 that this democracy was not for export, and that a policy unambiguously rejected by chiefs and people alike could still be foisted on Nyasaland, came as a blow which weakened his credibility in Nyasaland and contributed to his decision to leave London for the Gold Coast.[25]

What is more, the events of 1953, culminating in the police and military action during the 'Cholo disturbances' in August and September, brought home at once the autocratic character of the colonial state and the limitations of Congress's leadership. Threatened by the Governor, Colby, with the fate of his father, who had been executed during the Chilembwe rising of 1915, Chinyama publicly repudiated the use of violence in the Southern Province and withdrew the passive resistance campaign.[26] His resignation as president a few weeks later was followed by the collapse of the membership to a low of four or five hundred and the descent of Congress into political obscurity. Not until 1956 and the election of Masauko Chipembere and Kanyama Chiume to the Legislative Council did the Nyasaland African Congress re-emerge as a credible political force.[27]

Mass nationalism

It is no exaggeration to say that between 1956 and 1964 the Nyasaland African Congress (re-born in September 1959 as the Malawi Congress Party) was the most popular, dynamic and successful political party in Central Africa—one that ranks alongside TANU in Tanganyka and the CPP in the Gold Coast as among the leading nationalist movements in Africa. Yet it is also the case that in these years elements of a totalitarian ideology, deeply intolerant of dissent in its most innocent form, began to appear. It is with the relationship of these two forces that the next section will deal.

Most accounts of mass nationalism in Malawi begin with the return of Dr Banda to his homeland in June 1958, but by that time changes in the movement were already well under way. At the central level, Chipembere and Chiume had brilliantly exploited their unexpected election to the

24. Rhodes House Library, Oxford, Creech Jones Papers, MS Brit. Emp. S. 332, Box 7, Hastings K. Banda to Arthur Creech Jones, no date [1945].
25. Philip Short, *Banda* (Routledge & Kegan Paul, London, 1974), pp. 66–80.
26. MNA. ACC 19/JRC/4/1, G. W. Footman, Chief Secretary to J. R. Chinyama, 10 September 1953; press statement by J. R. Chinyama, September 1953; Short, *Banda*, pp. 77–78.
27. See PRO. CO 1015/961, Political Intelligence Report appendix, 'The Political Situation in Nyasaland at the end of April 1956'.

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Legislative Council by embarking on a series of stinging criticisms of colonial policy which turned the official Hansard into a best-selling broadsheet. A new statement of policy had been published declaring that the intention of Congress was 'To press for adult suffrage throughout the Protectorate in order to return a democratic government acceptable by all people'.[28] And with this aim in view, Chiume, abetted by the Marxist Flax Musupole and Dunduzu Chisiza, had spearheaded a recruiting drive which raised Congress's paid-up membership from 1,000 in April 1956 to 13,000 in October 1957 and which increased the number of branches in the Northern Province from half a dozen in 1956 to 34 in May 1958.[29] Women still remained peripheral to the movement, but Rose Chibambo, having served as treasurer of the Blantyre branch of Congress from 1954, was appointed to the Central Executive Committee by the then President, T. D. Banda, in 1957.[30]

In the same year, T. D. Banda created a youth organization, the 'Kwaca Boys', one of whose first actions was to threaten the senior Congress politician, Manoah Chirwa, with violence for refusing to resign his membership of the Federal Parliament.[31]

From 1958 the pace of political agitation accelerated. This is not the place to consider the sources of village-level discontent except to state that, under Dr Banda's leadership, Congress proved exceptionally astute in developing a political rhetoric to which a wide range of disparate interest groups was able to respond. Few inroads were made into the small trade union movement prior to the banning of the party in March 1959.[32] But, from October 1958, and for the first time in the country's history, crowds of young marginalized men came out on Blantyre's streets in defiant demonstrations in support of Congress. They were joined from January 1959 by increasing numbers of women activists in Mzimba, Zomba and elsewhere who spoke at political meetings and participated in public demonstrations. Many of these enrolled themselves in the Women's League, a body particularly active in Blantyre and Zomba, which was founded by Rose Chibambo on Banda's instructions in September 1958.[33] Across the country, teachers, churchmen and others associated with the Livingstonia and Blantyre synods of the Church of Central Africa

28. PRO. CO 1015/1748, 'Statement of Policy of the Nyasaland African Congress'.
29. PRO. CO 1015/1748, CO 1015/1749, Political Intelligence Reports, October, November 1957, May 1958.
30. 'A Brief Biography of Amazon Leader Mrs Rose Chibambo', *Malawi News*, 12 October 1961.
31. PRO. CO 1015/1748, Intelligence Report for August 1957.
32. John McCracken, 'Blantyre Transformed: Class, Conflict and Nationalism in Urban Malawi', paper presented at conference on 'Africa's Urban Past', School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London, 1996.
33. PRO. CO 1015/1749, Political Intelligence Report for January 1959. The best published account of popular nationalism in 1958–59 remains *Report of the Nyasaland Commission of Inquiry*, 1959 [the Devlin Report], Cmnd. 814.

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Presbyterian (CCAP) identified themselves closely with the nationalist cause, though less support was forthcoming from active members of the Roman Catholic, Anglican and Dutch Reformed Churches, all of whose leaders attempted to distance themselves from politics.[34] Peasant involvement was at its greatest in the Northern Province—the site of 48 out of a total of 63 branches of Congress in existence in October 1958.[35] Elsewhere, popular rural support was patchy: strong in the Cholo, Lower Shire and Nkota Kota districts where ethnic and economic divisions tended to coincide; weaker in other parts of the country. Chiefs in the north were virtually unanimous in backing the Congress line. In the south and centre, however, significant divisions emerged with some chiefs aligning themselves to Congress and others to the colonial state.

Special Branch reports are an important source of information on Congress activities. Yet, as a British judge noted in 1959, they 'are not always reliable, particularly when they are summarizing'.[36] In particular, it is evidence that the Special Branch frequently exaggerated the extent of intimidation in explaining how Congress obtained its support.[37] Even with this qualification in mind, however, there can be little doubt that the growing strength of Congress was accompanied by an intolerance of opposition which the leaders did little to quell. No doubt the authoritarianism of the colonial state—the restrictions placed on the holding of public meetings, the maintenance of a comprehensive system of censorship—played a major part in provoking the new response even before the banning of the party and the arrest of many leaders in March 1959. By January of that year nationalist politicians like Manoah Chirwa who disagreed with Congress's policy of a total boycott of federal institutions stood in real danger of physical assault. Abandoning his previous policy of 'leniency' and 'diplomacy', Dr Banda went out of his way to denounce 'moderates' and 'Capricorns' with a vehemence that stunned African politicians in Zimbabwe.[38] In this he was joined by his younger colleagues whose rhetoric was no more restrained.

As those (like myself) who met him in exile in Dar es Salaam can vouch, Masauko Chipembere, Banda's principal lieutenant and later opponent, was an exceptionally thoughtful and reflective politician. But, as he himself noted in an autobiographical sketch written around 1961 Chipembere's 'natural external politeness or shyness' did not prevent him

34. See John McCracken, 'Church and State in Malawi: the Role of the Scottish Presbyterian Missions, 1875–1964', in I. Phiri, K. Ross and J. L. Cox (eds.), *The Role of Christianity in Development and Reconstruction* (Nairobi, 1996) pp. 58–67; K. N. Mufuka, *Missions and Politics in Malawi* (Limestone Press, Kingston, Ontario, 1977).
35. PRO. CO 1015/1749, Political Intelligence Report for October 1958.
36. *Report of the Nyasaland Commission of Inquiry*, p. 33.
37. For a notably sensitive and balanced discussion of this issue see *Report of the Nyasaland Commission of Inquiry*, p. 20.
38. See Ranger, *Are We Not Men?*, p. 170.

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making 'some very volatile and aggressive speeches'.[39] His views on political democracy, as expressed in 1957, were relatively flexible in their vision of the future:

> Let us not listen to those who talk of party-politics. This is not the stage for party-politics for us. Party-politics are a dangerous thing during pre-liberation views. They are the ideal thing when you have achieved independence, or are near the achievement of independence. But now we are in the stage of struggle and what we need in this stage is one solid powerful mass movement embracing all people and enjoying the active support of our Chiefs.[40]

As independence approached, however, Chipembere's political vision hardened. Writing in 1960, he denounced the multi-party system as 'a system of Government with a built-in subversive mechanism' and rejoiced that 'In Africa, fortunately this political ailment seems likely to be avoided'.

> The new independent African states have all shown themselves to be keen to inherit only the good fruits of Western thinking and to reject all its destructive myths and political superstitions. They are developing what Britons deride as 'monolithic' States. This is nothing to worry about. Africa must evolve systems that suit her people's attitudes and temperament.

He concluded by noting that even in Europe parliamentary democracy was not the only system employed. 'Half the population of Europe lives under one type of authoritarian state or another, and they are none the worse for it.'[41]

Chipembere's vision of the new African state reflects the triumphalist tone adopted by most, though by no means all, Congress politicians following the founding of the Malawi Congress Party by Orton Chirwa in September 1959. Often regarded as the Nyasaland African Congress by another name, the MCP quickly emerged as an infinitely larger party than its predecessor, much more populist in character and distinctly more totalitarian in its aims.

The expansion of the MCP from 12 branches in October 1959 to 112 in February 1960 and a staggering 1,842 in October 1961 made it almost certainly the fastest growing political party in Central Africa. Figures for total membership must be treated with caution. But in the view of the Special Branch, which had no reason to inflate numbers, the paid-up membership had reached 67,000 in February 1960 and was in excess of

39. Leaflet entitled *Mr Masauko Chipembere* (Malawi Press Limited, Limbe, no date, *c.* 1961).
40. PRO. CO 1015/1748, Henry B. Chipembere, 'A Letter to the African People of the Southern Province of the Nyasaland Protectorate', May 1957.
41. PRO. CO 1015/2445, H. B. M. Chipembere, 'Something about Opposition Parties', *Malawi News*, 26 November 1960.

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100,000 by October 1961.[42] Recruitment was slowest in the Northern Province, where it was initially feared that the party had been established as a rival to the NAC. But large-scale support was gained in the Lilongwe and Fort Manning districts of the Central Province, the first time that the Chewa heartland of Malawi had been brought fully into nationalist politics. Under Rose Chibambo and Vera Chirwa the League of Malawi Women flourished. But it is noticeable that the main task of its members appears to have been 'to turn out as a body to greet Dr Banda at his public appearances' and to sing and dance in Banda's honour.[43] Dancing, indeed, was utilized extensively as a means of popular mobilization. Wherever Banda travelled on his triumphant tour of the Northern and Central Provinces in June 1960, people gathered in their thousands to perform such dances as *nyau* and *malipenga*, both of which had previously been subjected to official disapproval.[44]

For sympathetic observers of the MCP in the run-up to the 1961 elections, the clear evidence of widespread village-level support, of the active involvement of peasants as well as teachers and of young as well as old, made it a movement of exceptional attraction. Writing of his visit to Nyasaland in June 1960, the anonymous editor of the radical broadsheet, *Dissent* (in fact, the young Terence Ranger) emphasized 'the solidity and solidarity of Malawi support' which he compared a little wistfully with his experience of Southern Rhodesia.

Yet as Ranger noted, if his first impression had been of 'the strength and popularity of Malawi', his second impression was of 'Malawi's problems'—problems that arose 'from the very fact that Malawi is a national movement, containing within itself so many elements which under other circumstances would be competitive or hostile'.

> How is it going to be possible to reconcile the interests and influence of the village headman and the 'emergent' Malawi branch officers? . . . And then what of the Youth League, as they march down the hillside twenty minutes or so after the meeting has begun, with drums and chants and peculiar home-made Party uniforms of their own?

What in particular of the 'respected elder . . . beaten up as a "stooge" ' or of the 'able and patriotic headmaster persecuted with libel, threat and open disobedience by his own pupils'?[45]

Ranger's emphasis on generational conflict as a source of political violence is an important insight which historians of Malawi have been

42. PRO. CO 1015/2444, Political Intelligence Report for February 1960; CO 1015/2445, Special Branch report on The Malawi Congress Party, fourth edition, 14 October 1961. The MCP claimed 300,000 members in April 1960 (*Malawi News*, 9 April 1960) and 600,000 in October 1961.
43. Lucy Mair, *The Nyasaland Elections of 1961* (Athlone Press, London, 1962) p. 33.
44. For a vivid account of this tour see the report by Aleke Banda in *Malawi News*, 14 June 1960.
45. 'Return to Malawi', *Dissent*, 9 June 1960, pp.1–5.

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unwise to ignore. Yet while it was the case that militant Youth Leaguers between December 1959 and 1961 acted as a semi-independent force with only limited controls from above, their links with the MCP leadership remained profound and it is doubtful whether their behaviour was ever seriously at odds with Dr Banda's wishes.[46] Indeed, it can be argued that Banda profited from his ability to present a public face of moderation while distancing himself from the acts of violence which he relied upon others to perform.

The consequence was that between April 1960 and July 1964, the MCP developed as an absolutist body both in terms of its own internal structure and in its attitudes to Malawian society. As early as August 1958, Banda had claimed dictatorial powers over Congress including the right to make all appointments and dismiss any member of the party.[47] On his release from Gwelo gaol he added to his authority, becoming Life President of the party in 1960 and the centre of a personality cult which the Publicity Secretary, Kanyama Chiume, was particularly energetic in promulgating. 'For MCP members', so Lucy Mair wrote of the 1961 elections, 'support of the party is a moral norm, not just a matter of opinion . . . the election was conceived not as a contest of which the outcome was, at least theoretically, in doubt, but as a sort of ritual demonstration of support for Dr Banda'.[48]

Members of opposition parties such as Chester Katsonga's Christian Liberation Party were subjected to harassment and assault and even interest groups sympathetic to but independent of the MCP became targets of attack. 'All churches are ONE AND THE SAME whatever their names', Aleke Banda asserted in the *Malawi News* in April 1960 in a generalized assault on mission-based churches, including the CCAP. 'When we get our own government such things will have to be put to a stop or else Africans will start their own National Church. Education will, of course, be "nationalised" so that no propaganda for imperialism can be continued in schools.'[49]

Criticism of independent trade unions or workers' associations was even more fiercely expressed. Suzgo Msiska and Chakufwa Chihana were both active members of the MCP as well as being General Secretaries of the Transport & Allied Workers Union and the Commercial & General Workers Union respectively. But when, in September 1961, Msiska called out on strike more than 800 drivers and mechanics in Blantyre in a demand for higher wages, Aleke Banda and Augustine Bwanausi of the

46. See Special Branch reports on the League of Malawi Youth, 29 January 1960 (PRO. CO 1015/2444); 4 August 1961 (CO 1015/2445); 31 October 1961 (CO 1015/2445).
47. PRO. CO 1015/1749, Political Intelligence Report for August 1958.
48. Quoted in Richard Hodder-Williams, 'Some Aspects of the Genesis of Political Ideas in Malawi', paper delivered at the ASAUK conference, Liverpool University, September 1974.
49. *Malawi News*, 23 April 1960.

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MCP were quick to condemn his action.[50] The dispute grew over the next few months with Yatuta Chisiza stating that the unions might have to be brought under government control and the 20 year-old Chihana accusing the MCP of betraying the interests of Malawian workers.[51] He and Suzgo Msiska were suspended from Party membership in June 1962, the first step in undermining the independence of the unions. Both men were initially successful in rallying support from their members but at a time when the MCP was at the height of its popularity their fate had been effectively sealed. With considerable courage, the labour leaders brushed aside the diatribe launched against them by Dr Banda in August and resisted repeated attempts to expel them from office. MCP disapproval mounted, however, in February 1963 when they came out in public opposition to the Trade Union (Amendment) Ordinance stripping the unions of their independence and this time they had no defence. Under pressure from the new Minister of Labour, Willie Chokani, Msiska was forced to resign as Secretary-General in May and a year later left the country.[52] Chakufwa Chihana remained in office up to the end of January 1964 when he too resigned to the general regret of his members. Meanwhile, confidence in the remaining leaders of the trades union movement had slumped 'since it is believed by the rank and file that they dare do nothing in opposition to the Government's employment and wages policy'.[53] Many were subsequently absorbed into the civil service or else into the party bureaucracy.

It is a tragic feature of the absolutist mass party that the demands it made frequently hit most hard at the most harmless members of society. Those in search of a Christianity with genuine Malawian roots had no need to look further in the early 1960s than to the Jehovah's Witnesses with their origins in Eliot Kamwana's Watchtower movement from 1909 and to the Providence Industrial Mission (PIM) founded by the nationalist hero, John Chilembwe, in 1900. But while John Chilembwe and Eliot Kamwana were now lauded by the MCP as 'our national heroes and martyrs', their successors, fatally impeded by a wish to keep themselves detached from politics, refused to register for elections or to purchase Party cards.[54]

In the aftermath of the 1961 elections, this detachment was regarded by MCP vigilantes as little short of treason. The first wave of attacks on Jehovah's Witnesses by militant members of the Malawi Youth League

50. Much of this section is drawn from McCracken, 'Blantyre Transformed'.
51. PRO. DO 183/136, Political Intelligence Report for May and June 1962; Short, *Banda*, pp. 156–7.
52. PRO. DO 183/136, Political Intelligence Reports March and April 1963.
53. PRO. DO 183/136, Political Intelligence Report for August 1963.
54. The quotation is contained in Dunduzu Chisiza to George Shepperson, 28 October, 1956, Professor Shepperson's personal collection.

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took place in the early months of 1962 but came to a halt when Dr Banda expressed his disapproval.[55] The start of the pre-independence election campaign late in 1963, however, was marked by a further wave of political violence which was actively encouraged from the top.[56] Virtually no incidents were reported from the Northern Province. But in other parts of the country attacks on members of religious sects increased rapidly to over 600 reported cases in January 1964, the beginning of the registration period for the elections, and to more than 1,200 in the following month. In the majority of instances the damage was confined to the burning of houses and crops and the beating up of men and women, but at least eight Witnesses and a member of the PIM were killed. In one incident in the Dedza district, Youth League vigilantes attacked a Providence Industrial Mission church during a service, killing one member of the congregation and beating several others severely. In two separate cases on the Lilongwe Plain, a total of five Witnesses were murdered by youths dressed as *nyau* dancers—an indication of the fact that even before independence the secret village-based *Nyau* society, often seen as the guardian of Chewa cultural values against foreign intrusion, was being utilized by elements within the MCP as a instrument of rural oppression.[57]

Not until the belated intervention of Dr Banda on 23 February did the number of violent incidents fall, helped no doubt by the reluctant decision of the PIM leader, Dr Malekebu, in January to reverse his previous policy and instruct his members to register.[58] Thereafter, persecution of Jehovah's Witnesses came to a temporary halt, only to re-emerge on a larger scale in 1967 when they were once more subjected to a premeditated campaign of arson, rape and assault.[59]

55. PRO. DO 183/136, Political Intelligence Reports for March, April and August 1962.
56. Gwanda Chakuamba, then member of the Legislative Assembly for Chikwawa District and now Deputy Chairman of the MCP, and Aleke Banda, then Publicity Secretary of the MCP and now Minister of Finance in the United Democratic Front government, were among the politicians accused by the Special Branch of inciting their followers to violence. PRO. DO 183/137, Political Intelligence Reports for January and February 1964.
57. For details see PRO. DO 183/136 and DO 183/137, Political Intelligence Reports for December 1963 and for January and February 1964. These reports were made available to Dr Banda but not to other ministers. Useful discussions of *nyau* include J. M. Schoffeleers and I. Linden, 'The resistance of the Nyau Cult to the Catholic missions in Malawi', in T. O. Ranger and I. Kimambo (eds.), *The Historical Study of African Religion* (Heinemann, London, 1972); J. M. Schoffeleers, *River of Blood* (London, 1992) ch. 2. See also Deborah Kaspin, 'Chewa Visions and Revisions of Power: Transformations of the Nyau Dance in Central Malawi', in John and Jean Comaroff, *Modernity and its Malcontents* (London, 1993), pp. 34–57.
58. PRO. DO 183/137, Political Intelligence Report for March 1964. Malekebu, John Chilembwe's successor, was Malawi's first qualified medical practitioner, having graduated from the Meharry Medical College in Nashville, Tennessee in 1919, 18 years before Dr Banda.
59. Short, *Banda*, pp. 257–8. For additional information see Tony Hodges, *Jehovah's Witnesses in Africa* (Minority Rights Group, London, 1985); Africa Watch, *Where Silence Rules: The suppression of dissent in Malawi* (London, 1990).

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Democracy

Faced with the evidence of deep-rooted intolerance, it is tempting to agree with Crawford Young that, for nationalist forces in the era of decolonization, democracy was little more than 'a theory of challenge to the colonial order, a vehicle to contest its hegemony and accelerate its departure'.[60] But while Young is right to stress the importance of 'the autocratic tradition of the colonial era' in shaping political attitudes, there is a danger in taking this argument too far. Kanyama Chiume probably spoke for the majority of his colleagues when he looked forward on the eve of independence 'to the day when this country will be so organised that there will be no opposition at all and all of us will be sitting like in a real *mphara*' [traditional meeting place]. But he failed to convince fellow politicians like Orton Chirwa and Yatuta Chisiza with his further claim 'that there is absolutely nothing wrong in dictatorship, and, therefore, if we, through the Malawi Congress Party, established a dictatorship here, we can only be described as the loyal servants of God'.[61]

Chiume's assertions stand in striking contrast to the thoughtful analyses of the post-colonial situation produced by Dunduzu Chisiza, the one intellectual rival of Dr Banda and the only Congress Party politician to provide a coherent democratic alternative to his views.[62] Educated both at Livingstonia and at the Aggrey Memorial College near Kampala, Chisiza gained his first experience of nationalist politics as a founder-member of the radical City Youth League in Salisbury, Southern Rhodesia, from where he was deported to Nyasaland in 1956.[63] Described by Chipembere as 'a self made intellectual of no university attainments but one who surprises us all with his mental powers', Chisiza was a voracious reader, lacking any systematic ideology and hence particularly receptive to new ideas.[64] As a convert to the Bahai faith, he was a convinced believer in religious toleration. But he was also a passionate cultural nationalist with a consuming interest in the struggle of the Malawian people against colonialism, the subject of a book that he planned to write.[65] During his

60. Crawford Young, 'The African Colonial State and its Political Legacy', in Donald Rothchild and Naomi Chazan (eds.), *The Precarious Balance: State and society in Africa* (Westview Press, Boulder, 1988), pp. 25–66.
61. *Proceedings of the First Meeting of the First Session of the National Assembly of Malawi*, 26–29 May 1964, pp. 124–25.
62. For a useful biographical sketch see D. D. Phiri, *Malawians to Remember. Dunduzu K. Chisiza* (Longman, Blantyre, 1974). Chisiza's ideas are most fully expressed in D. K. Chisiza, *Africa-What Lies Ahead* (New Delhi, 1961), and in D. K. Chisiza, 'The Temper, Aspiration and Problems of Contemporary Africa', paper delivered to the Nyasaland Economic Symposium, July 1962. This was summarised under the title, 'The Outlook for Contemporary Africa' in *The Journal of Modern African Studies*, **1**, 1 (1963).
63. For an admiring account of Chisiza's role in Southern Rhodesian politics see Nathan Shamuyarira, *Crisis in Rhodesia* (Andre Deutsch, London, 1965) pp. 26–28.
64. Quoted in *Report of the Nyasaland Commission of Inquiry*, July 1959, p. 14.
65. See the account by George Shepperson, with whom Chisiza corresponded between 1956 and 1960, in Roderick J. Macdonald (ed.), *From Nyasaland to Malawi: Studies in colonial history* (East African Publishing House, Nairobi, 1975).

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years of imprisonment in Gwelo, he turned his attention to economics and started a regular correspondence with Walter Rostow, one of the most influential American development economists of the 1960s, who sent him draft chapters from the book he was then working on, *The Stages of Economic Growth*.[66] It was in part through his contacts with Rostow, that Chisiza was able to obtain the funds that allowed him to mount the ambitious Nyasaland Economic Symposium in Blantyre in July 1962.[67]

Chisiza's analysis of the challenge facing post-colonial Africa contains three main elements: a generalized account of the communal character of African culture; an emphasis on the importance of the role of the state in economic modernization; and a hard-headed discussion of the difficulties facing African rulers in reconciling the demands of the state with the variegated interests of the people. As an unabashed convert to modernization theory, Chisiza was convinced of the need for 'strong man government', which he defined, quoting from an American professor, 'as a dictatorship which the citizens choose to put up with'.[68] But his concern with state-led economic growth was qualified by his liberal beliefs in a modern state in which 'respect for the dignity of "the human individual and the sanctity of his personality" shall be recognised' and in which 'basic human rights shall be guaranteed'.[69]

Chisiza's attempt to reconcile these two contradictory concerns is a central feature of his writings. It pervades his discussion of the relationship between governments and opposition parties, between the state and trade unions, between central governments and chiefs, and above all between the leader and the masses. In all of these cases, Chisiza's own preference is for a political approach which accepts the need for a strong central government while recognizing the legitimacy of sectional interests. Thus, opposition parties should continue to function but ideally as co-opted members of 'national governments—the type of all-party government that Britain had during the world war'. The trade union movement should be free from political control while accepting its 'voluntary subordination' to the nationalist movement. Chiefly authority should be protected but the central government must take over some of the functions previously performed by traditional rulers. 'A distinction must be very clearly drawn between enemies of the state and enemies of ones party', with the former being 'dealt with in accordance with the law of the land' and the latter protected from victimization.[70]

66. The subtitle of *Stages of Economic Growth*, 'A non-Communist Manifesto', succinctly demonstrates where Rostow's sympathies lay.
67. Rostow, who by this time had been seconded to the State Department, subsequently held discussions with Chisiza in Washington. See PRO. CO 1015/2498, file entitled 'Symposium on Economic Development, Blantyre, 1962'.
68. Chisiza, 'Relating Principles of Economic Development to Africa', p. 8.
69. Chisiza, 'Relating Principles', p. 3.
70. Chisiza, *Africa-What Lies Ahead*, p. 11.

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Dictatorship, Chisiza saw as one of the most pressing dangers to be faced, not least because of the difficulty in drawing 'the line between a strong man and a dictator'. The following passage, taken from his address to the Economic Symposium in July 1962, can be read as a prophetic commentary on the experiences of those men like Chipembere and Chiume who built up Banda as a leader only to discover, too late, that he had established an authority which they could not control:

> If a nationalist movement is to achieve the goal of independence, it is vitally important that one of the leaders should be elevated well above the others; that his former equals should look upon themselves as his juniors; and that they should accept his decision as final; and that they should pledge loyalty to his leadership. But once independence has been achieved, the problem of reconciling submissiveness to the top leader and individual initiative on the part of second-level leaders arises. To a man who has been surrounded by submissive associates for a long time, the exercise of initiative by his associates is easily misconstrued as a sign of rivalry and disloyalty.[71]

In his pamphlet, *Africa-What Lies Ahead*, Chisiza returned to the argument from a different direction and with a blunt recognition of the limitations of politicians:

> The real problem is posed by those leaders who will lapse into dictatorial tendencies either because their countrymen trust them too much or too little. When too much trust is reposed in a leader (sometimes) the thing goes to his head and makes him believe that he is infallible. Such a man is not likely to brook criticism or to welcome alternative suggestions. It is his idea or nothing. On the other hand, when a brilliant, self-assured, well-meaning leader is begrudged trust or is dealing with a dense populace, he too will tend to force his measures through in a dictatorial manner believing that the masses will appreciate what he is doing later.

What such leaders required, he suggested was 'a dose of humility'.

> They need to remind themselves that getting to the top of the political tree does not necessarily mean that they are more intelligent than other people. Indeed politics, the world over, has the uncanny knack of attracting the most mediocre of brains . . . In framing policies and designing measures, therefore, leaders must rely [more] on public opinion and the opinions of colleagues than on their imagined superior intellects. The task of leadership involves following as well as leading.[72]

Chisiza's language is refreshingly different in tone from the stifling political rhetoric of the Banda years. But it would be wrong to push the contrast too far. An advocate of the interventionist state, Chisiza, like Banda, was an unabashed believer in strong government. Like Banda, he was in favour of politicians entering actively into business.[73] And like Banda too, he looked

71. Chisiza, 'The Temper, Aspirations and Problems of Contemporary Africa', p. 8.
72. Chisiza, *Africa-The Way Ahead*, pp. 16–16. There is a misprint in the final sentence which I have corrected here.
73. Chisiza, 'The Temper, Aspiration and Problems of Contemporary Africa', p. 8.

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to the Agricultural Production and Marketing Board to 'help the Government in siphoning off money from the growers for further development'—a policy diametrically opposed to the interests of Malawian peasants.[74] On social issues, he was no more enlightened or progressive. The main problem for African women, he observed, was that not enough of them possessed the domestic and social talents required by their male partners.

> Modern African young men want their wives (a) to know how to prepare traditional as well as western dishes; (b) to know how to rear children in the modern way; (c) to share in their social interests such as dancing etc.; (d) to maintain a modern home which they can be proud of; (e) to be able to entertain guests both the African and western way depending upon the type of guests; (f) to know enough English to be able to read useful manuals and to converse in English when necessary; (g) to master the art of washing and ironing clothes, and (h) to know how to dress like film stars without playing the part.[75]

Yet if some of Chisiza's views mirrored the conventional attitudes of the time, other went well beyond them. In one incautious passage he came close to implying that the essence of democracy was popular acceptance of a dictator. But, in practice, it is clear that he rejected such an absolutist posture and instead reverted to a position closer to that of Levi Mumba and Sangala in his recognition of the virtues of diversity. It was a far cry from Dr Banda's definition: 'A Government chosen by the people themselves—whether it is a dictatorship or not, as long as it is the people who choose the dictator, it is not a dictatorship. That's all. That is what democracy is.'[76]

Whether Chisiza was capable of providing Malawians with an ideological alternative to Banda must remain a matter of doubt. What one can say is that his death in a road accident in September 1962 removed an obstacle from the path to the totalitarian state. Other ministers, notably Chisiza's brother, Yatuta, were later to fight a rearguard action once it became clear that Banda, in reintroducing Preventive Detention in August 1964, was constructing a weapon which could be turned upon themselves. But by this time, the case for a democratic society had been fatally weakened.[77]

74. *Proceedings of the 3rd Meeting of the 76th Session of the Legislative Council*, 6–7 March 1962, p. 159. It was left to Michael Blackwood, the settler leader, to remark: 'I did hear with some surprise the remark . . . about syphoning off the money from the growers for development projects. I always understood that this was one of the things that the growers objected to, and that they always required the right price for their crops and not some hidden tax put on them by Government.'
75. Chisiza, *Africa-What Lies Ahead*, p. 22.
76. Speech to annual convention of MCP, 17 October 1965, quoted in Short, *Banda*, p. 260.
77. PRO. DO 183/168. D. C. Cole, British High Commissioner to K. J. Neale, 12 August 1964; to Sir Arthur Snelling 20 August 1964. There are several accounts of the cabinet crisis. Those I have found most useful are: Short, *Banda*, ch. 10; T. D. Williams, *Malawi: the Politics of Despair* (Ithaca, N.Y., 1978), pp. 196–229; Andrew Ross, 'White Africa's Black Ally', *New Left Review* (September–October 1967); Andrew Ross, 'The Malawi Cabinet Crisis of 1964', unpublished paper, 1984; Leroy Vail & Landeg White, 'Tribalism and the Political History of Malawi', in Leroy Vail (ed.), *The Creation of Tribalism in Southern Africa* (James Currey, London, 1989) pp. 179–84. My own initial analysis is contained in John McCracken, 'African Politics in Twentieth-Century Malawi' in T. O. Ranger (ed.), *Aspects of Central African History* (Heinemann, London, 1968), pp. 206–08.

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Conclusion

Looking from our present vantage point, it is worth asking what connections exist between the popular democratic movement of the 1990s and earlier political movements in Malawi. Should we see the events of 1992–94 as representing, in some sense, a rediscovery of a Malawian democratic tradition or would we wish to conclude that democracy in Malawi is essentially a product of more recent events—the building of a modern civil society through educational and economic change and the gradual erosion of the credibility of the Banda regime? Conversely, how far was the cabinet crisis, leading to the dismissal or resignation of Chipembere and his colleagues in September 1964, a decisive turning point in the political culture of Malawi and how far was it a logical culmination of much that had gone before?

The answer to these questions must begin with the recognition that the cabinet crisis, while clearly an event of major importance in the construction of the post-colonial state, did not involve a fundamental transformation in the character of the MCP. Already, prior to 1964 a totalitarian strain deeply intolerant of dissent had entered into Malawian politics. Yet while it was the case that Malawi democracy was an endangered species in the 1960s this is not to imply that it did not exist. How far pre-colonial traditions of accountability were carried into twentieth century political discourse in Malawi is a subject worthy of further discussion. Here it need only be said that from the 1940s onwards some politicians like Mumba and Chisiza successfully articulated a broadly democratic creed drawing as much from their internalized experiences as from external intellectual traditions.

The final point concerns the ambiguous and contradictory character of the nationalist movement in Malawi—and indeed, more widely, of nationalist movements in Africa and beyond. To an extent that it is difficult to exaggerate, Malawi nationalism was a genuinely liberating force, first in the sense that it contributed significantly to the breaking of the Federation and the ending of colonial rule, second in that it provided a stage on which previously marginalized groups, including some women and some youths, could perform. At the same time, however, popular participation did not equal popular empowerment, nor, more importantly, did it reflect that respect for individual rights and minority opinions on which democracy must be based. It is the challenge for Malawians in the 1990s to succeed where their predecessors failed in reconciling these various goals.

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